“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 14

A Brief Description of the Childhood Pastimes

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 “I worship Śrī Caitanya. Remember Him in any way at all, and the difficult becomes easy; forget Him, and the easy becomes difficult.” (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 20.1)

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Thus I have given an outline of the Lord’s birth, telling how the son of Yaśodā became the son of Śacī.

4 I have told the pastimes of His birth briefly and in order; now I shall name, one by one, the chief events of His childhood.

5 I worship the enchanting childhood pastimes of Kṛṣṇa, who came as Caitanya. Though they seem like the doings of an ordinary human child, within they are interwoven with the acts of the Lord Himself.[1]

6 At the very start of His childhood pastimes, as Śrī Caitanya lay on His back, He showed His father and mother the divine marks on His feet.[2]

7 In the house the two of them saw the prints of tiny feet, and in them a flag, a thunderbolt, a conch, a disc and a fish.

8 At the sight both were filled with wonder, unable to tell whose footprints these could be.

9 Miśra said, “The child Gopāla is present in our *śālagrāma-śilā*. I think He takes on a form and plays about the house for His own delight.”

10 At that moment Nimāi woke and began to cry. Śacī took Him on her lap and nursed Him.

11 As she nursed Him, she looked at her son’s feet, and when she saw those same marks on them, she called Miśra.

12 The sight filled Miśra’s heart with joy, and he quietly sent for Nīlāmbara Cakravartī.

13 Seeing the marks, Cakravartī smiled and said, “When I cast His birth chart, I foresaw this and wrote it down.

14 Thirty-two marks adorn a great personality, and I see every one of them on this child’s body.

15 “A great personality bears thirty-two marks: five parts of his body are long, five fine, seven reddish and six raised; three are short, three broad and three deep.” (Sāmudrika, 3)[3]

16 His hands and feet bear the marks of Nārāyaṇa. This child will deliver all people.

17 He will spread the Vaiṣṇava dharma far and wide, and through Him both His families will be delivered.[4]

18 Hold a great festival and invite all the brāhmaṇas. Today is an auspicious day; I shall perform the naming ceremony.

19 He will uphold and nourish all people, and that is why His name is Viśvambhara."[5]

20 Hearing this, Śacī and Miśra rejoiced all the more. They invited the brāhmaṇas and their wives and held a great festival.

21 Some days later the Lord began to crawl on His knees, and He showed many wonders.[6]

22 On the pretext of crying He made everyone chant the name of Hari: all the women would call out "Hari!", and the golden Lord would laugh.[7]

23 Later still He began to walk, and He played all sorts of games with the other children.

24 One day Śacī brought puffed rice and sweets, filled a dish, and gave it to Him, saying, "Sit down and eat."

25 With that, Śacī went into the house to do her work, and the child began to eat earth on the sly.[8]

26 When Śacī saw it, she came running and cried out, "Oh dear, oh dear!" She snatched the earth away and said, "Why are You eating earth?"

27 The child wept and said, "Why are you angry? You gave Me earth to eat — how is that My fault?

28 Puffed rice, sweets and all food are only earth in another form. This is earth and that is earth; why make any distinction?[9]

29 The body is earth, and food is earth — think it over and see. You blame Me without thinking; what can I say?"

30 Inwardly astonished, Śacī said to Him, "Who taught You such *jñāna-yoga*, just so You could eat earth?

31 Food is earth transformed, and when we eat it, it nourishes the body. But eat earth itself, and disease sets in and the body wastes away.

32 In a pot, which is earth transformed, I fetch water; but try to hold it in a lump of earth, and the water soaks away."

33 To keep Himself hidden, the Lord said to her, "Mother, why did you not teach Me this before?

34 Now that I know, I will not eat earth any more. When I am hungry, I will drink at your breast."

35 Saying this, the Lord climbed onto His mother's lap and, with a little smile, began to nurse.

36 Thus, on one pretext or another, He would show His majesty, and afterwards, slipping back into the ways of a child, He would hide it again.

37 Three times He ate the food a brāhmaṇa guest had cooked, and afterwards, in secret, He delivered him.[10]

38 Another time some thieves found the Lord outside and carried Him off; but He bewildered them and came home riding on their shoulders.[11]

39 On the day of Ekādaśī, pretending to be ill, He ate the food offered to Viṣṇu in the house of Jagadīśa and Hiraṇya.[12]

40 He would take the children into the neighbours' houses and steal food to eat, and He would beat the other boys.[13]

41 The children all complained to Śacī, and when she heard them, she scolded her son a little:

42 "Why do You steal? Why do You beat the other children? Why do You go into other people's houses? What do You lack at home?"

43 Hearing this, the Lord grew angry, went into the house, and smashed every pot in it.

44 Then Śacī took Him on her lap and comforted Him, and the Lord, knowing He was at fault, felt ashamed.

45 Once He struck His mother with His soft little hands, and when He saw her faint, He began to cry.

46 The women said, "Bring her a coconut, and then Your mother will recover."[14]

47 He went out and brought back two coconuts, and everyone was astonished at the marvel.

48 Sometimes He bathed in the Gaṅgā with the other children, and the girls would come there to worship the gods.

49 When they had bathed in the Gaṅgā and begun their worship, the Lord would come and sit down among them.

50 He would say to the girls, "Worship Me, and I will grant you a boon. Gaṅgā and Durgā are My maidservants, and Maheśa is My servant."[15]

51 He would smear Himself with sandal paste and put on the flower garlands, then snatch the offerings and eat them — sweets, rice and bananas.

52 The girls said angrily, “Listen, Nimāi! By village ties You are a brother to us all.

53 It is not proper for us to say this to You, but do not take the gods’ offerings, and do not misbehave!”

54 The Lord said, “I give you all this boon: each of you will have a most handsome husband.

55 He will be learned and refined, young and rich in wealth and grain, and each of you will have seven sons, long-lived and wise.”

56 Hearing this boon, the girls were delighted at heart, but outwardly they scolded Him with feigned anger.

57 If some girl ran off with her offering, the Lord would call after her angrily:

58 “If you are stingy and will not give Me your offering, you will get an old husband — and four co-wives!”

59 The girls grew frightened at these words: “Perhaps He knows something, or perhaps some god has entered Him.”

60 So they brought their offerings and held them out before Him, and when He had eaten, He gave them the boon they longed for.

61 In this way He showed His mischief to everyone, yet no one was ever unhappy; it brought them all joy.

62 One day Vallabhācārya's daughter, Lakṣmī by name, bathed in the Gaṅgā and came to worship the gods.[16]

63 When the Lord saw her, His heart was drawn to her; and at the sight of the Lord, Lakṣmī felt joy within.

64 A natural love awoke in them both, though the mood of childhood still veiled its true form.[17]

65 Seeing each other, both rejoiced at heart, and on the pretext of worshipping the gods they let their feelings show.

66 The Lord said, "Worship Me, for I am Maheśvara, the Supreme Lord. If you worship Me, you will receive the boon you desire."

67 Lakṣmī placed sandal paste and flowers on His body, offered Him a garland of mallikā jasmine, and bowed to Him.

68 Receiving her worship, the Lord began to smile, and by reciting a verse He accepted the sentiment of her heart.

69 "O chaste ones, I know your resolve to worship Me. I accept it, and it deserves to come true." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.22.25)[18]

70 After this pastime the two of them went home. Who can fathom the deep pastimes of Caitanya?

71 Seeing Caitanya's mischief, everyone, out of love for Him, would come to Śacī and Jagannātha with complaints.

72 One day Śacī-devī scolded her son and went to catch Him, but He ran away.

73 Then the Lord Viśvambhara, upholder of the universe, sat down contentedly on the cast-off pots in the refuse pit.[19]

74 Śacī came and said, “Why have You touched these unclean things? Go and bathe in the Gaṅgā — You have made Yourself impure.”

75 In reply He spoke to His mother of *brahma-jñāna*, spiritual knowledge. She was astonished, but still she made Him bathe.[20]

76 Once, as Śacī lay resting with her son, she saw that divine beings had come and filled the house.

77 Śacī said, “Go, my son, and call Your father.” At His mother’s bidding the Lord went outside.

78 As He walked, anklets jingled on His feet, and His father and mother were startled to hear them.

79 Miśra said, “This is a great wonder! Why do we hear anklets on the child’s bare feet?”

80 Śacī said, “I saw another wonder too: radiant divine beings came and filled the courtyard.

81 They raised such a clamour that I could not make out what they said; whom they were praising I can only guess.”

82 Miśra said, “Whatever it may be, there is nothing to worry about. All I want is for Viśvambhara to be well.”

83 One day, seeing his son’s mischief, Miśra scolded Him severely and taught Him what dharma requires.

84 At night he dreamt that a brāhmaṇa came and spoke to him angrily:

85 “Miśra, you know nothing of who your son truly is. You scold and beat Him because you think of Him as merely your son.”

86 Miśra said, “Be He a god, a perfected being or a sage — however great He may be, now He is my son.

87 To raise and teach his son is a father’s own dharma. If I do not teach Him, how will He come to know the heart of dharma?”

88 The brāhmaṇa said, “If He is divine and perfect by nature, His knowledge is complete in itself, and teaching Him is in vain.”[21]

89 Miśra said, “My son may well be Nārāyaṇa; even so, it is a father’s dharma to teach his son.”

90 So the two of them discussed dharma. Miśra’s parental love was pure; he knew nothing else.[22]

91 At this the brāhmaṇa went away well pleased, and Miśra awoke in utter astonishment.

92 He told the dream to his friends and kinsmen, and all who heard it marvelled.

93 Thus Gauracandra played His childhood pastimes, and day by day His parents’ joy grew.

94 Some days later Miśra placed chalk in his son’s hand, and within a few days He had learnt all the letters with their twelve *phalās*.[23]

95 This, in order, is the outline of His childhood pastimes; Vṛndāvana dāsa has described them at length.[24]

96 Therefore I have outlined the childhood pastimes briefly and, for fear of repeating him, have not told them in detail.

97 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: “Though Gaura’s pastimes look human, they are not of this world (*aprākṛta*).” *Anubhāṣya*: *laukikīm api* — though they resemble the doings of people in this world; *īśa-ceṣṭayā valitāntarām* — “inwardly joined with the acts of the Lord”, with His supernatural endeavours. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the childhood pastimes look worldly, yet the acts of God are woven into them. ↩
2. Heading in the edition to 6–7: “The marks of the conch, disc, flag, thunderbolt and fish on His soles.” *Anubhāṣya*: *uttāna* means lying face upwards, on one’s back; another reading is *utthāna*, “rising”: the baby tried to stand on His feet and, not yet used to it, tumbled down like any child. ↩
3. Heading in the edition: “The thirty-two marks of a great personality”; the source is the *Sāmudrika*, verse 3. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the long are the nose, arms, jaw, eyes and knees; the fine — skin, hair, finger joints, teeth and body hair; the reddish — the corners of the eyes, the soles, palms, palate, lower and upper lip, and nails; the raised — chest, shoulders, nails, nose, waist and face; the short — neck, shanks and generative organ; the broad — waist, forehead and chest; the deep — navel, voice and character (*sattva*). One who bears these thirty-two marks is a *mahāpuruṣa*, a great personality. ↩
4. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the two families are His father’s and His mother’s. ↩
5. The *Anubhāṣya* cites the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Ādi 3): “At His birth the whole world grew well again, as when Nārāyaṇa once upheld the earth. Therefore His name is Śrī Viśvambhara.” The name Viśvambhara also occurs in the *Atharva-veda* (book 2, *anuvāka* 3, *prapāṭhaka* 3, mantra 16.5): “O Viśvambhara, uphold and protect me with all that sustains the world, *svāhā*.” ↩

6. Heading in the edition: “Supernatural acts displayed.” *Anubhāṣya* (after the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 3): the beautiful Lord crawled about on His knees, and little bells tinkled at His waist. One day a snake was gliding through the courtyard, and the Lord, at play like a child, caught hold of it. The snake coiled itself up, and He lay down on top of it; then the snake left Him and slipped away. ↩
7. Heading in the edition: “At the name of Hari His crying stops.” *Anubhāṣya* (after the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 3): the lotus-eyed Lord would cry until He heard the name of Hari. Everyone understood the sign, and as soon as He began to cry they would clap their hands and sing “Hari!” — and so, just as He wished, He made them all chant the holy name without cease. ↩
8. *Anubhāṣya*: this episode is one of those that Vṛndāvana dāsa left out of the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* and that the author, as he promised in Ādi 13.49, now supplies. ↩
9. Headings in the edition: “Nimāi’s philosophical reply” (v. 27), “All is a transformation of clay” (v. 28), “The difference between a substance and its transformations, or between the favourable and the unfavourable” (v. 31). *Anubhāṣya* on 27–33: to take things for enjoyment is an activity of inert (*acit*) nature, and there is no service of Hari in it. The followers of the impersonal (*nirviśeṣa*) doctrine mistakenly hold that what is favourable to Kṛṣṇa’s service is of one kind with what is unfavourable. That such a notion is a crude, unripe error of worldly thought — that this “earthen” impersonal reasoning is barren — Mahāprabhu showed through His mother’s words, by the simple example of clay and the pot. ↩
10. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: a wandering brāhmaṇa came as a guest to the house of Śrī Jagannātha Miśra. Miśra gave him all he needed for cooking, and he prepared a meal; but as soon as he offered it in meditation to Gopāla, Nimāi came and began to eat it. The brāhmaṇa cooked again, and the same thing happened. The third time he cooked when everyone in the house was asleep, and again Nimāi came and began to eat. The brāhmaṇa cried out in despair, and then Nimāi said, “O brāhmaṇa, when I was Yaśodā’s darling in Vraja, this happened to you before. Now too, drawn by your devotion, I have shown Myself to you out of mercy.” Seeing his worshipful Lord, the brāhmaṇa, enraptured with great love, honoured the remnants of the prasāda, and the Lord forbade him to reveal this hidden pastime. *Anubhāṣya*: see the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 3. ↩
11. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Mahāprabhu, still very small and decked in gold ornaments, was playing outside the gate. Two thieves lifted Him onto their

shoulders and carried Him off, promising Him sweets, but they meant to kill the child in the forest and take His ornaments. Mahāprabhu, however, spread His māyā and led them astray, and with Him on their shoulders they arrived at the gate of His own house. There the relatives who had been running about searching for Him saw them; the thieves set the child down and fled, and He was carried with great care into Śacī's courtyard. *Anubhāṣya*: see the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 3. ↩

12. Heading in the edition: "On Ekādaśī He eats the offering to Viṣṇu from the house of Hiraṇya and Jagadīśa." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: on Ekādaśī an offering for Viṣṇu was being prepared in the house of Jagadīśa and Hiraṇya Paṇḍita. Mahāprabhu wanted to taste it and sent His father there. Hiraṇya and Jagadīśa were amazed: "Today is Ekādaśī, and an offering for Viṣṇu is being cooked in our house — how could so small a child know of it? Surely there is a Vaiṣṇava power in Him." And they sent the food to the child. Mahāprabhu had asked for it on the pretext of illness, saying that if He ate the offering to Viṣṇu His illness would pass. He fed it to the other children, ate some Himself, and so was "cured". Their house lay about a *krośa* south-east of Miśra's, and a child could not have known what was happening there. *Anubhāṣya*: see the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 4. ↩
13. *Anubhāṣya* (after the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 3–4): every day, just for fun, He would steal food from the neighbours — in one house He drank the milk, in another He ate the rice, and where He found nothing He broke the pots; and if there was a baby in the house, He made it cry. ↩
14. Heading in the edition to 45–47: "He strikes His mother and, seeing her swoon, brings coconuts that were hard to find." The *Anubhāṣya* cites the *Caitanya-maṅgala* of Locana dāsa (Ādi): a radiant woman, smiling, took Viśvambhara by the chin and said, "Bring Your mother two coconuts, and then Śacī, Your mother, will live." Viśvambhara was delighted and at once brought a pair of coconuts. ↩
15. *Vara* means both "boon" and "bridegroom"; the girls worshipped the gods to win a good husband (cf. 54–55, 58). ↩
16. Heading in the edition: "Meeting with Lakṣmī-devī, Vallabha's daughter." *Anubhāṣya* on 62–68: Vallabhācārya was a royal paṇḍita living in Navadvīpa. *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (44): "Formerly he was the great Janaka, king of Mithilā; now he is Vallabhācārya, and he is held to be Bhīṣmaka as well." Śrī Gaurahari's first marriage was to his daughter, Lakṣmīpriyā-devī. *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (45): Śrī Jānakī and Rukmiṇī appeared in Caitanya's pastimes as his daughter named Lakṣmī; and another verse there tells how

Vallabhācārya's daughter Lakṣmī, who had descended with the Lord, went with her friends to bathe in the heavenly river and there came before His eyes. ↩

17. Heading in the edition: "The eternal, natural love of the two, and their delight." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Lakṣmī is the Lord's eternal consort, and the Lord is Lakṣmī's eternal husband; their eternal love is therefore *sāhajika*, inborn, and here it appeared veiled by the mood of childhood. ↩
18. *Anubhāṣya*: these are Śrī Kṛṣṇa's words to the gopīs who had kept the vow to Kātyāyanī longing to attain Him; after returning their garments, He saw their desire. *Mad-arcanam* is worship meant to attain Me; *saṅkalpa*, the heart's cherished wish, which out of shyness they had left unspoken; *anumodita*, "accepted". *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: "O chaste ones, I have understood the purpose of your worship, and it gives Me great joy; your wish deserves to be fulfilled." ↩
19. Heading in the edition: "Nimāi sits on the discarded pots." The *Anubhāṣya* cites the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Ādi 7): "The Lord sat Himself down, as if on a throne, on the pots thrown away after the offering to Viṣṇu. His mother came, saw Him and cried, 'Oh dear, my child, You must not sit here!' But the Lord said, 'Everywhere I see one, without a second. There is no defilement at all in these pots. Pots in which food is cooked for Viṣṇu are never impure; their touch makes any other place pure.'" ↩
20. Heading in the edition: "The son instructs His mother in the knowledge of Brahman (*brahma-jñāna*)." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Lord said, "Mother, 'defiled' and 'undefiled' are only human notions; there is no truth in them. In these pots you cooked for Viṣṇu and offered the food to Him — how can they ever be defiled? And the soul is eternally pure — how can 'defiled' and 'pure' apply to it?" Hearing such teaching, His mother was astonished and made Him bathe. ↩
21. Heading in the edition to 88–89: "The brāhmaṇa's words and Miśra's reply." *Anubhāṣya*: seeing that Miśra took Nimāi for an untaught child and wished to teach Him so as to awaken knowledge in Him, the brāhmaṇa said: "Your son is an eternally perfect divinity, yet you mistake His eternal, natural knowledge for a child's folly and set about teaching Him. That is in vain, and it is not proper for you." Here the *Anubhāṣya* also refers to Antya 4.174–176 and cites the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* (11.28.4; 11.19.45; 11.21.3): in the transcendent there is no distinction of "good" and "bad" — such distinctions belong to the duality of the mind; "pure" and "impure" are prescribed among things of one nature only for the sake of dharma, worldly dealings and the upkeep of life. ↩

22. Heading in the edition: “Miśra’s pure parental love for the Lord.” *Anubhāṣya*: *Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu* (Western Division, Fourth Wave): the abiding sentiment (*sthāyi-bhāva*) of parental affection, nourished by *vibhāva* and the other elements, is called *vatsala-rasa*. And the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* (10.8.45): Yaśodā looked upon as her own son Hari, whose glory is sung by the three Vedas, the Upaniṣads, Sāṅkhya, Yoga and the Sātvata scriptures. ↩
23. Heading in the edition: “Chalk is placed in Nimāi’s hand.” *Anubhāṣya*: the twelve *phalās* are the signs by which other sounds are joined to a Bengali letter: *repha*, *ṇa*, *na*, *ma*, *ya*, *ra*, *la*, *va*, *ṛ*, *ṝ*, *ḷ* and *ḹ*. ↩
24. Heading in the edition: “These chief events of the childhood pastimes are described in the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*.” ↩